

A

The school system

This is the **system** for **state education** in most parts of England and Wales. State schools are free and operated by the country. Parents pay to send their children to **private** schools.

age	education
3	Almost all children attend [go to; <i>fml</i>] nursery school for up to 15 hours a week.
5	Everyone starts primary school .
11	Pupils [students at school] go to secondary school .
16	Pupils take/do GCSE exams , in up to ten subjects. Then they can go to a college for vocational [job] training , e.g. hotel management or travel and tourism courses, or they can stay at school for two more years.
18	Pupils take 'A' level exams in three or four subjects, and then they can leave school and get a job or go on to university [continue their education at university], or go to a college for further education/training, e.g. teaching or business studies.

B

The school timetable

The school day is **divided into** about 5–7 lessons, and over the course of a week, most pupils **do/study** about ten **subjects**, including English, maths, history, science, etc. There's usually a one-hour lunch **break** [period of rest between work], and a break in the morning and afternoon as well.

Language help

In American English the subject is **math**, but in British English it is **maths**.

The school year is usually divided into three **terms** [periods of study], with each term being about 13 weeks, although some schools are now having shorter terms and more frequent holidays. At the end of the school year, pupils usually **take/do** exams before they **break up** [end classes for the term]. After the summer holidays, they **go back** [return] for the new school year.

C

School rules*

“In the **past** schools generally had more rules, and if you **broke the rules**¹, you were **punished**. At my school, for example, pupils sometimes had to **stay behind**² and write an essay. I used to **get into trouble**³ for wearing **lipstick**.

I remember we had to **call** the **male** teachers ‘sir’ and **female** teachers ‘miss’, and we had to **wear** a horrible **uniform**⁴. Nowadays, the **atmosphere**⁵ is more **relaxed**⁶: older pupils can often **dress**⁷ the way they want – as long as they’re reasonably **smart**⁸ – and the teachers are not as **strict**⁹.”

* instructions telling you what you must or must not do

¹ did something wrong

² stay in a place when others leave

³ do something wrong and be punished

⁴ special clothes

⁵ the feeling in a place or situation

⁶ comfortable and informal

⁷ wear clothes

⁸ well dressed and not too casual

⁹ A strict teacher punishes pupils who do something wrong.



lipstick